DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Is Ruah HaKodesh?

Derech Hashem 3:3:1-3

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 3, Chapter 3, paragraphs 1-3 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 6 December 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Where we are in the book

Part 1 of Derech Hashem was about the Kadosh Barukh Hu. Part 2, learned over the previous year, was about His relationship with us, hashgahah. Part 3, begun after Sukkot, is about the soul. Chapter 1 described the parts of the soul and sleep; chapter 2, finished before Hanukkah, showed how nature can be manipulated through God's names and the angels for good, and through witchcraft for bad. Chapter 3, a short chapter, is "Ruah HaKodesh and Nevuah": divine inspiration, with a brief introduction to prophecy. Chapter 4 will explain prophecy in detail, and chapter 5 Moshe's prophecy.

"The Ramhal is all about stage after stage." Dreams are beyond the ordinary but very limited. Using God's names is higher. Now we go up again.

Paragraph 1: hokhmah, binah and daat

God placed in human nature the ability to learn and understand the world. The Rabbi set out three levels.

Hokhmah is raw knowledge: the facts of science, the sun rising and setting, the seasons.

Binah is deduction, "to understand one thing from another". Every new scientific theory is binah, built on accepted facts. It needs cleverness, but it is still within natural human reach.

Then God gives a further level that is bestowed rather than worked for: an illumination that reaches the mind so that a person knows something with certainty, without any doubt or mistake, including its roots, causes and results. This is Ruah HaKodesh. A participant named it: **daat**.

The Rabbi explained that daat is usually translated "knowledge", but in the Torah it means intimate, deep connection, which is why the Torah uses it for the bond of husband and wife. The Es HaDaat was the tree of deep connection to God. God said: I will give you hokhmah and binah always, and daat when I decide. You cannot take it by eating from the tree.

Feeling it in your bones

"Sometimes you can hear a shiur, you can hear a sermon, you can learn something in Torah, and this is not just knowledge, but you actually, wow, it penetrates your heart." Those things you never forget, because you experienced them rather than just understood them.

He applied it to the class itself. Listening now is hokhmah. Going home and deducing new things is binah. Relating it to your own life and experiences while learning is daat, a form of Ruah HaKodesh, and for that you need God to give it.

The Torah's source is in Sefer Shemot, at the building of the Mishkan: God placed wisdom "in the heart of every wise-hearted person". How did they get wisdom in the first place? They had hokhmah; God gave them the intimate feeling for building the Mishkan, so that it was not a technical engineering project but a connection.

His own example: after learning Eruvin, knowing the Gemara is hokhmah, applying it to modern roads is binah, but when he walked out at the end of the day and saw eruvin everywhere he looked, "that's daat. That's you're living it." And that brings certainty.

A participant asked whether one can sit back and expect Ruah HaKodesh. No: it comes to those who strive for hokhmah and binah. Prayer and closeness to God help, but it needs Torah and Tefillah together. "Let's work on getting hokhmah first."

Paragraphs 2-3: clarity, the future and levels

Through this third level a person understands things with greater clarity, and also things beyond natural understanding, including the future and hidden matters. There are many levels: how much God bestows, and when, for example more on Shabbat, a festival or Yom Kippur; how direct it is; and what is revealed. But in every case it is something actually felt.

Do not confuse it with something more common: a thought that simply drops into your head. The Rabbi gave the Yiddish word *Einfall*, "it fell in". You are stuck on a sugya or in a business meeting, and suddenly it comes together. In a broad sense Hazal also call this Ruah HaKodesh, a hidden influence, but true Ruah HaKodesh is felt and experienced.

The group's discussion

A participant asked where the line falls between the two. The Rabbi: the light bulb moment is the broad kind; the deep inner sense, felt in your bones, is rarer. He added that the Gemara suggests women connect to things more deeply, which is why we find great prophetesses and women with Ruah HaKodesh.

Another participant said such clarity once came to him at a low point, when he suddenly saw "this is not my place". The Rabbi suggested it may come from previous merit, or simply be a gift: God gives a person the energy to start again. He also said work need not be a distraction: an artist, musician or scientist can experience the divine all day.

Next: prophecy, far higher than even the top level of Ruah HaKodesh, which is why we have Ruah HaKodesh today but not prophecy.

Summary

- Hokhmah is raw knowledge; binah is deduction; daat is deep, felt connection.
- Ruah HaKodesh is understanding bestowed by God, known with certainty and felt in the bones.
- It comes only to those who work at hokhmah and binah, with Torah and Tefillah together.
- It has many levels, and can include insight into hidden things and the future.
- A sudden intuition is Ruah HaKodesh only in a broad sense.

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